

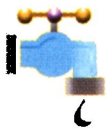


means major re-tooling of many of their factories to make them more energy efficient or a big shift to alternative fuels. It involves huge capital costs that most countries have baulked at. It also means getting their people to cut down their consumption levels using disincentives and levying a heavy tax on carbon. Progress on that count too has been unsatisfactory. The strategy of developed countries has been to delay implementation of a major global compact to reduce emission. They make the right noises at international forums but when it comes to walking their talk most don't. Meanwhile, they are also busy trying to divide the consensus among developing countries on issues of responsibility.

For India, the strategy would be to push developed countries into making meaningful emission cuts. They could even join hands with China and other weighty developing nations. On its part, India will not agree to mandatory emission cuts as its per capita GHG emissions is one of the lowest in the

ECO FRIENDLY: Prime Minister Manmohan Singh at the release of the national action plan

ity missions to combat climate change and bring down India's emissions in the long term



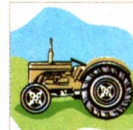
WATER MISSION: To promote efficient water use, augment supply in critical areas and ensure effective management of water resources. To have better management of surface and groundwater. Also conserve wetlands.



SUSTAINING HIMALAYAS: To enhance monitoring and conservation of the Himalayan ecosystems, empower local communities for management of ecological resources and promote sustainable tourism.



A GREEN INDIA: To reduce fragmentation of forests, enhance public and private investments for plantations, upscale joint forestry management and promote conservation of biodiversity. Afforest degraded lands.



SUSTAINABLE AGRICULTURE: To focus on four crucial areas—dryland agriculture, risk management, access to information and promoting the use of biotechnology. Also to develop drought and pest resistant varieties.



STRATEGIC KNOWLEDGE: To research substantive domains of climate science. Have climate modelling to improve quality of projections, promote data access between ministries and have an integrated knowledge network.

Illustrations by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

negotiations have begun for a new compact with even more stringent emission cuts. Europe has taken the lead but the US is still on its favourite hobby horse that India and China should also agree to mandatory emission cuts. There is again an attempt by developed countries to obfuscate their own lapses and confuse responsibilities. Shyam Saran, the prime minister's special envoy on climate change, says: "The name of the game seems to be to deflect attention from the key issue which is what the developed countries are going to commit to in terms of cutting their own emissions."

The game is also about energy. Industrialised countries that had based the growth of their economies on unlimited supply of fossil fuels are in a quandary as oil becomes costly and the threat of global warming grows. Given that it is their combined emissions in the past 200 years that has brought the earth's climate to the brink of catastrophe, the onus lies on these countries to clean up the atmosphere by significantly reducing their emissions. That

world (see *chart*) and is 20 times less than that of the US. But it is open to taking measures to mitigate the impact of climate change that could result in reducing its GHG emissions. But the caveat is that developed countries must ensure a verifiable and measurable transfer of technology and finance to enable India to do so. Implementing its national action plan would help India make its arguments more convincing in crucial international negotiations.

I Make a big switch to renewable energy

India may have been under pressure from industrialised countries to bring out a national action plan but if it did so it was largely because it now regards pursuing an enlightened green policy as vital to its own national interests. As Sunita Narain of the Delhi-based Centre for Science and Environment, says: "The plan offers no major solutions but it puts the issue into a neat framework and lays down priorities.